

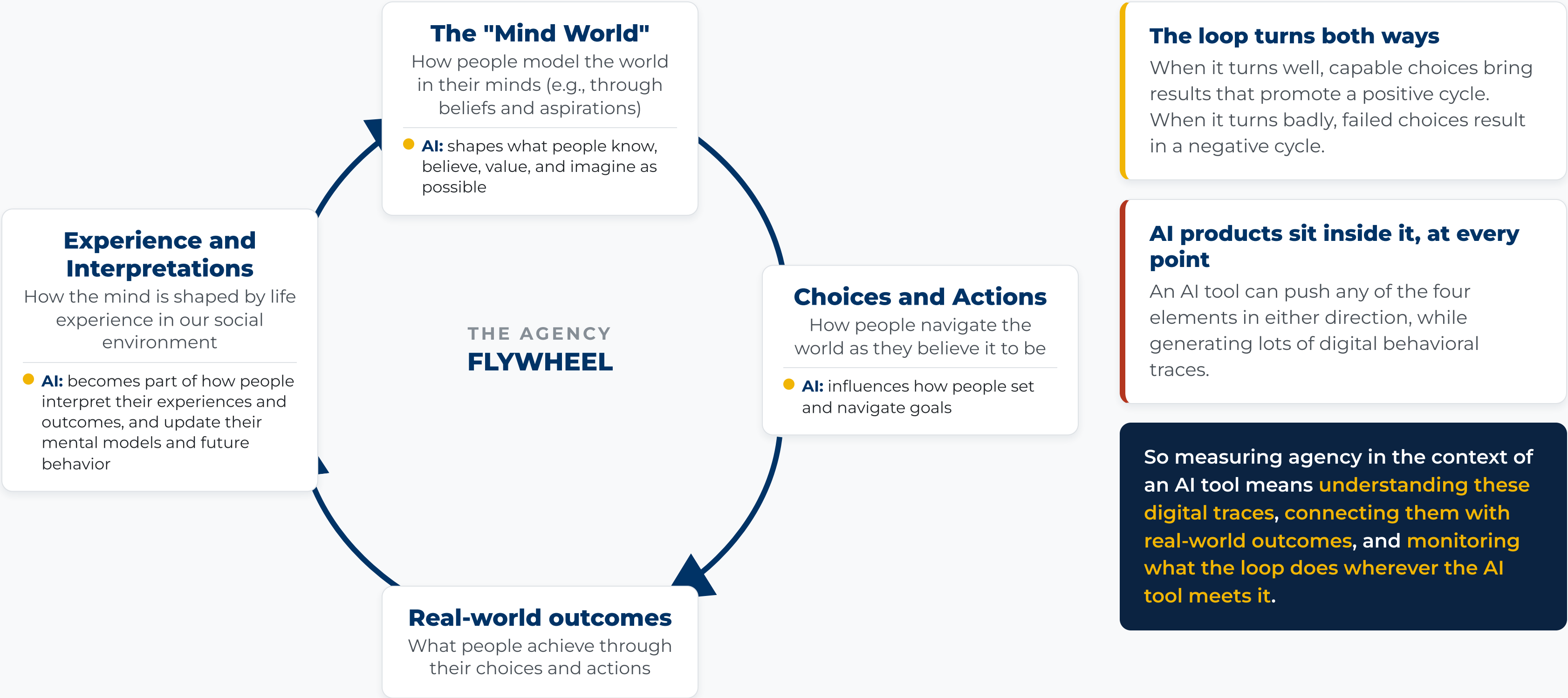
2026 NAIROBI ONSITE · TALK + WORKSHOP · 90 MINUTES

Measuring **agency** in the context of AI tools

As social services develop AI tools, how can we tell when AI tool use is expanding or undermining human agency? What is agency? Why should we measure it? How can we measure it to know whether AI tools are actually supporting it?

Zezen Wu · Behavioral Scientist, The Agency Fund

Our worldview of agency in a flywheel



AI can **expand** agency, and it can hamper it

CAN EXPAND

THE FULL FINDING

People stay with tools that **make them feel more capable**, even when the tools make mistakes. AI can strengthen agency in five ways: instrumental, cognitive, affective, relational, and structural.

FLIP BACK

CAN HAMPER

THE FULL FINDING

A ChatGPT-style math tutor boosted practice scores by 48%, but students scored **17% below the control group** once the AI was removed. A guaranteed tutor that offered hints rather than solutions eliminated the harm, yet students using either tool remained unaware of the gap between feeling supported and actually learning.

FLIP BACK

CAN HAMPER

THE FULL FINDING

Across 1,375 participants, an accurate chatbot raised reasoning accuracy by 25 percentage points, but a faulty one drove it 15 points below unbiased performance. People followed wrong AI advice on **roughly four in five consulted trials** and became more confident even when misled; time pressure, incentives, and feedback reduced but did not eliminate the effect.

FLIP BACK

In all three studies, people looked engaged and felt capable while it happened. Usage and satisfaction cannot tell expansion of agency from its erosion, **which is why we measure agency directly.**

Sources: [How AI Is Affecting Human Agency](#) (Jigsaw, July 2025) · [Generative AI without guardrails can harm learning](#) (PNAS 122(26), 2025) · [Thinking, Fast, Slow, and Artificial: the rise of cognitive surrender](#) (Wharton working paper, 2026).

In a typical research study where agency is explicitly in the theory of change...

Theories can be used to define agency.

In these studies, you usually strive to get full observability on the agentic process and design the program in a way to produce these signals of agency. For example, in **social cognitive theory**, people are agents who intentionally shape their circumstances. Agency has four core elements in this framework:



Source: [Bandura \(2001\), Social cognitive theory: an agentic perspective.](#)

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE: AN AI MENTOR HELPING LEARNERS DEVELOP A VIABLE BUSINESS IDEA

But in the context of NGOs iteratively developing AI tools where agency may or may not be central to the theory of change...

What you need to measure also depends on the forms of agency and how agency manifests in your product.

Agency with respect to the end goals

Can users make progress toward outcomes they value, whether through, around, or beyond the tool?

Internally experienced agency

People's thoughts and feelings

ON-PLATFORM DATA • IN-APP MICRO-SURVEY

control do they feel over reaching their ultimate goal?)
is the user about developing a successful business idea? How much
perceived control over their ultimate goal over time (e.g., How confident
Short-in-app surveys probing users' general sense of self-efficacy or

OFF-PLATFORM DATA • PHONE OR IN-PERSON SURVEY

control over their ultimate goal to emit.

Systematically probe users' general sense of self-efficacy or perceived

Longer phone-in-person surveys using validated agency measures that

 **FLIP BACK**

ON-PLATFORM DATA • CONVERSATION LOGS

demonstrating resilience despite difficulties.

OFF-PLATFORM DATA • RUBRIC-RATED PITCHES

outcomes like business earnings.

classroom observation of teamwork, ideally linked to downstream business ideas; published observations of ideas and pitches; or longer phone/in-person surveys tracking how users develop their

 **FLIP BACK**

Externally expressed agency

People's choices and actions

Agency with respect to the AI tool

Can users understand, question, adapt, and control the tool, deciding when and how to rely on it?

ON-PLATFORM DATA • IN-APP MICRO-SURVEY

question, to quote LA Mentor's advice.

OFF-PLATFORM DATA • VALIDATED SCALES

empowerment when a tool systematically probes users' trust in IA and perceived dependence versus longer phone/in-person surveys using validated agency measures that

 **FLIP BACK**

ON-PLATFORM DATA • DIGITAL TRACES

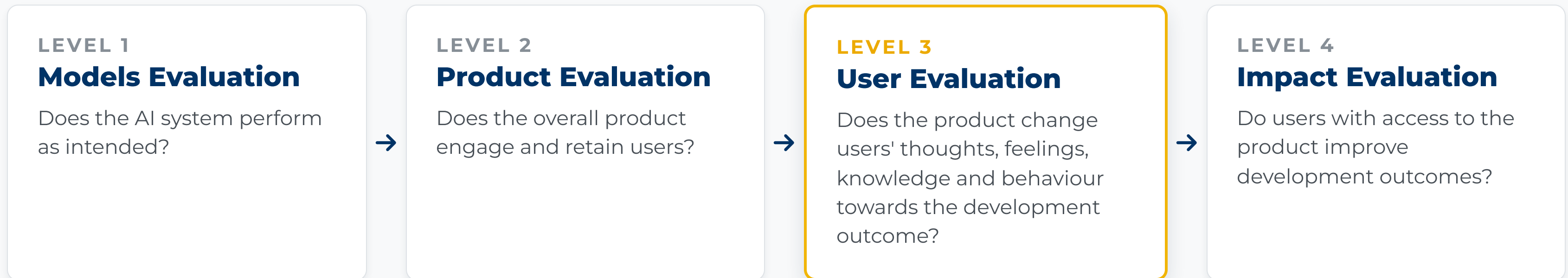
Digital traces (e.g., interaction patterns or conversation logs) showing whether users understand, question, or adopt an AI mentor's advice.

OFF-PLATFORM DATA • OBSERVATION AND INTERVIEWS

Opdrachtgever en/of afnemer van de dienstverlening
Onderneming

 **FLIP BACK**

Agency measurement sits at **Level 3**



Nobody can run an RCT on every product change. **Validated agency measures at Level 3** move when the product changes, and they speak to what Level 4 cares about. That is what lets teams anchor their A/B tests on something that matters.

HOW WE SUGGEST YOU DO IT • THREE STEPS THAT LOOP

Teams should specify what agency means for their specific users and contexts

1

Define agency for your local problem

What kind of agency is the tool supposed to support? **For whom? To what end?** Anchor the definition in your program's theory of change.



2

Measure with the right tools, on the right data, at the right moment

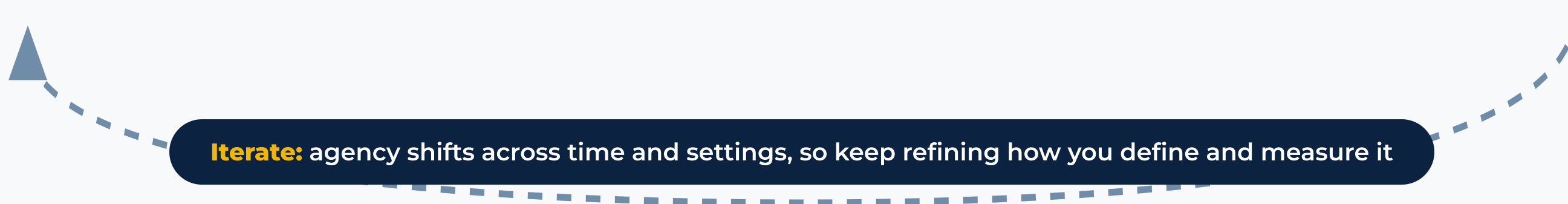
Combine **on-platform** signals, such as in-app surveys and digital traces, with **off-platform** surveys, interviews, observations, and records.



3

Test and validate your measurement tools iteratively

Check **reliability and validity** for your context, and compare LLM-based measures against a human-coded gold standard.



Can you identify signals of agency in human-AI conversations?

In this workshop, we focus on a specific agency measurement in the quadrant of **Externally expressed agency x Agency with respect to the end goals** (Do they act toward their goal?), which is especially relevant to AI tools. We aim to examine **human-AI conversations** in different domains, which can hold **rich signals of agency**. You will read **10 synthetic conversations** from one of the **three example domains**, answer **four questions and an open note**, and compare your labels with an **AI judge** at the end.

ACTIVITY • ~ 60 MINUTES

Work in pairs and identify signals of agency in synthetic human-AI conversations

1 Claim your link in the shared sheet

Scan the QR to open the sheet. Find your table's domain block, type your name next to the lowest unclaimed code — that row's link is yours.

2 Open the link on your phone or laptop

You will see ten conversations between users and a fictional AI product, plus the four coding questions.

3 Work in pairs to discuss the coding for about 40 minutes

Answer the four questions for each conversation and leave one open note. No worries if you can't finish all ten.

4 Then discuss learnings at your table for about 15 minutes

Find one conversation where you disagreed. Argue it out: what evidence did each of you use? Nominate your hardest case to code.

THREE SETS OF SYNTHETIC CONVERSATIONS
BASED ON AI PRODUCTS OUR GRANTEES
DEVELOPED

AI educational mentor

Business-idea coaching inside a school entrepreneurship program

AI health assistant

Post-visit follow-up line for clinic patients

AI agricultural advisor

Crop, weather and market Q&A for smallholder farmers



Scan to open the claim sheet

One link per person. Type your name to claim a row — **everyone can see the sheet live**, so a named row is taken.

Think about four questions & open codes

1

BELIEFS AND ASPIRATIONS

Belief or aspiration shift

Does the user express a new or changed sense of what is possible for them?

2

PURPOSEFUL ACTION AND CHOICES

Specific action or decision

Does the user state a specific action or decision they will take, or have already taken?

3

REAL-WORLD OUTCOMES

Links action to a life outcome

Does the user connect the actions or advice to a real-life outcome they care about: income, harvest, health, school fees?

4

INTERPRETED EXPERIENCE

Uses past experience

Does the user refer to a past success or failure and use it to inform what they do now?

OPEN NOTE Anything else you notice, especially the agency loop turning backwards: e.g., growing discouragement, over-reliance, decisions handed to the AI. Short conversations with nothing to code are normal.



SET

5 min

15 min

40 min

-1 min

+1 min

Start

Reset

Over to Calibrate: how well did we align?

1

People vs. people

How often did we give the same answer to the same conversation?

2

AI vs. people

An AI coded the same conversations with your exact rubric. Does it align with the room?

The point of the exercise is that once a rubric earns agreement between people, an AI can apply it consistently across **thousands of conversations**. That is what makes agency measurement scale.

Agency measurement is complex. **Try out these public tools to learn more.**

The blog →

Measuring Agency in a Digital Context, by The Agency Fund and Google Jigsaw

The Claude skill →

ask-agency-measurement: a coach that turns these frameworks into a plan for your product

The NotebookLM →

Curated papers and validated agency scales you can interrogate conversationally

The evaluation playbook →

The full four-level framework for evaluating GenAI products, level by level